planning metro frequency, timing and lighting infrastructure. "In India," he adds, "we plan for the average user and plug gender in as an add-on."

Moreover, says Shah, policy still focuses on cars, the main mode of transport for just three per cent of workers nationally (the city figure, 5.7 per cent, isn't that much higher). Streets, he argues, should be designed equally for people who do not seek speed: the elderly, children and women.

Governments usually go for the free or discounted ticket to promote bus travel for women. Karthick argues that the latter is more women-friendly, and scholarly opinion leans towards the need to prioritise last-mile connectivity and safe walking spaces as much as cost. When a woman gauges work opportunities, she is willing to pay, say studies, if the cost is not 'too much'. It obviously remains a factor. A working paper from February 2026 out of IIT Bombay, 'Ticket to ride: Impact of free public transport on women's workforce participation in India', by Udayan Rathore and Ashish Singh, found that free bus travel for women in five states raised paid work.

The agenda is unglamorous, but this kind of politics does more than win elections. One woman confidently going to work leads to one more, and before you know it, all the world's their stage. ■

—Jumana Shah



A woman negotiating a ride in Delhi AFP



"Policy is mostly about cars, the main mode for a minority of travelling workers. Streets should be designed for the elderly, children and women"

— JAGAN SHAH
Senior expert in urban development policy and practice

A holiday is no longer just an annual summer or winter break. Indians are travelling more frequently, going for weekend getaways, planning spontaneous trips and spending on experiences, whether it is a staycation with family, a concert in another city or a road trip to a lesser-known destination.

The latest Domestic Tourism & Expenditure Survey (DTES), conducted by the National Statistical Office between July 2025 and June 2026, puts this in perspective. Around 38 per cent of urban households and 35 per cent of rural households travelled at least once in the last 365 days for an overnight trip, be it for leisure, religious, health/medical or shopping reasons. This is almost double the trips from DTES 2014-15—only 19 per cent travelled for leisure, medical and shopping in 2014-15 (a caveat here: religious pilgrimage wasn't part of the earlier survey). The shift is reflected in the numbers. Tourism ministry's India Tourism Data Compendium 2025 records 4,287 million domestic tourist visits in 2025, up from 2,322 million in 2019.

Pilgrimage and religious activities accounted for 47.7 per cent of overnight trips—more than any other category. Following that was health/medical travel, accounting for 29.6 per cent, while holidaying, leisure and recreation made up 22.1 per cent. In 2014-2015, 65 per cent of the trips were for health/medical purposes, but with the above caveat.

Travel trends differ sharply between urban and rural India. While religious

THE SHORTCOMINGS

- **Indians are travelling more, but accommodation remains an issue. Better facilities needed**
- **Though public transport—buses and trains—is favoured, frequency, comfort are suspect**

THE SOLUTIONS

- **Destinations have to deliver a quality experience; lodgings are a key part of it**
- **State transport facilities have to improve, rural India still waiting at the bus stop**